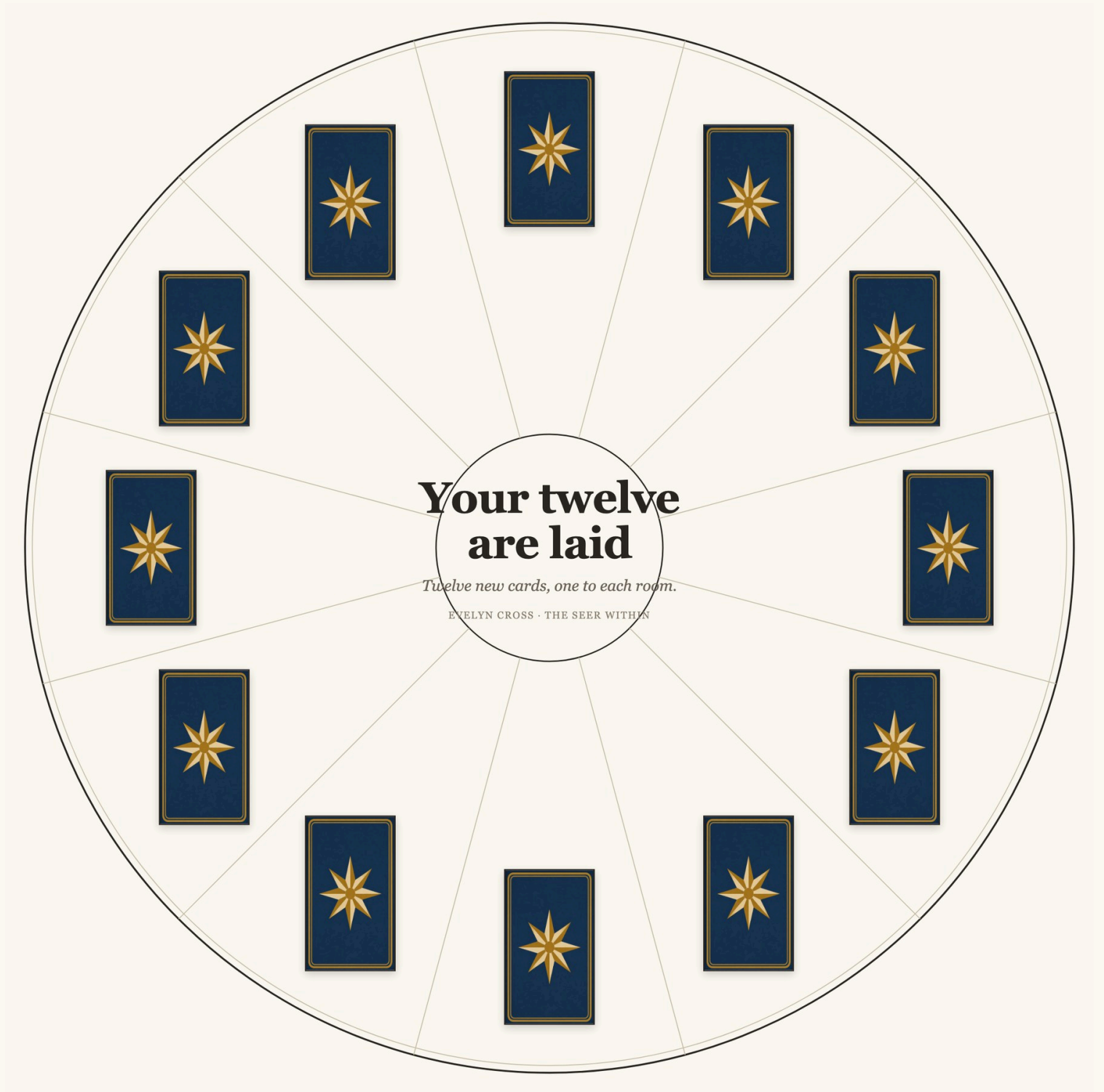




Laid for **Sarah** · 7 September 2026

YOUR TWELVE, AS THEY WERE LAID

- 1 yourself *Temperance*
- 2 what you own *the Wheel of Fortune · reversed*
- 3 what you say, and who you say it to *the Magician · reversed*
- 4 home, and what you came from *Judgment*
- 5 romance, and what delights you *the Devil*
- 6 work, health, the daily grind *the Fool · reversed*
- 7 who you are bound to *the Chariot*
- 8 what is hidden, and what comes through others *the Empress · reversed*
- 9 what you believe *the Hanged Man*
- 10 your standing *Strength · reversed*
- 11 your circle *the High Priestess*
- 12 what is being kept from you *the Hermit · reversed*

I laid these last night, at my own table, with the lamp on and the rest of the house asleep.

I had expected the noise to come from your fifth. Romance, the arrival, the question you have carried since my letter — that is where I was watching.

It came from your twelfth instead. The room of what is kept from you was louder than anything else on that table, and it was loud about a person.

So here is the shape of it, flat, dear. This is a good draw. The hard news in it sits in two rooms, your seventh and your twelfth, and neither of them ruins you.

The window for all twelve is the next two months. Nothing below runs on any other clock.

Your life happens in three of these rooms — the fifth, the seventh, the twelfth. A man arrives. A bond you are in keeps its heading. And a man already beside you is on his way out.

Every card here is a trump. I pull a twelve out of the Major Arcana only when a first draw asks for it — twenty-two cards, no minors, and a whole night of me. Yours asked.

The three cards from my letter are not in this spread; they said their piece already. What they left unfinished is settled below, each in the room it belongs to.

You paid a stranger to look at your life because you had run out of vantage on it from the inside. There is nothing shabby in that, and there is no accusation anywhere in these twelve. I would tell you if there were.

One thing before you start. Some of this will look as though it argues with itself — ease promised in one room, work demanded in the next.

Read all twelve before you decide what it says. The sense is in the arrangement, and no woman's life is consistent either.

HOUSE 1

yourself

The cosmos has guided your choice to Temperance, a card of two lives being blended



TEMPERANCE

A sun is marked on the angel's forehead, and on the breast a square with a triangle set inside it. Fire, held in a shape that will not let it spill. That is the make of you.

The water crosses from the high cup to the low one without falling straight. Nothing of yours is being wasted. Two parts of your life that have never agreed are being made into one workable thing, by degrees, while your attention is on other matters.

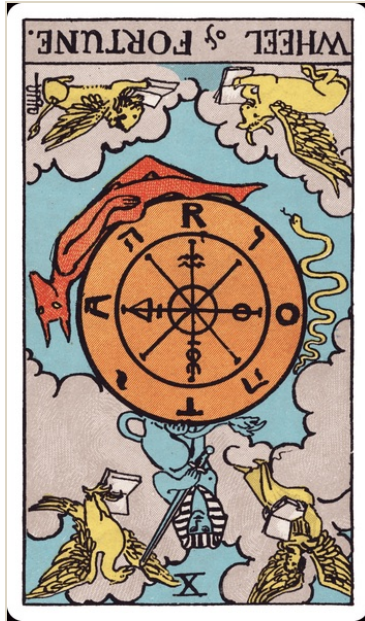
A crown shows faintly in the light between the hills. Taken as good fortune already on its way, it stops the pouring, and the season closes with nothing behind it to look back on.

One foot of yours is in the pool, dear, the other on the bank where the yellow flowers are, and this room gives you a quiet season of gain in exchange for the small daily portion you would rather skip.

The gain is not a mood. The second room names the door the first of it comes through.

what you own

The celestial wisdom has guided your selection to the Wheel of Fortune, a card of luck arriving late



THE WHEEL OF FORTUNE ·
REVERSED

The wheel hangs in open sky with nothing beneath it — no post, no axle, no hand at the rim. It turns because it turns. It never asks the woman whose money is on it.

Yours has been standing still. Something already set aside for you has not moved, and nothing you did or left undone put the brake on.

The door is a ledger, not a person, dear. Money owed to you comes back — a sum released through an office, a payment reissued, a figure you were told was settled and was not.

It comes on paper before it comes in hand, and the amount will be larger than the one you remember.

The eighth room has the Empress upside down in it: what reaches you through other hands, kept back past its time. The stall is sitting on somebody's desk, not in your habits.

The sphinx keeps its sword across the top and does not move. Below it, the dog-headed one is still climbing.

what you say, and who you say it to

The cosmic alignment has guided your choice to the Magician



THE MAGICIAN · REVERSED

Red roses hang above his head and white lilies come up out of the bed at his feet. Both are cultivated flowers — nothing in that garden seeded itself. Every word you put out has been tended like that, chosen, pruned, made presentable before it leaves you.

And the sideways eight floating over him touches nothing. The current runs in a loop above the table and never comes down into the four things laid out on it.

Three places to look. The answer you give when somebody asks how you are. The message you write out in full and then send a shorter one instead. And the counsel you hand over whole to a person who did not ask for it and will not use it.

That third one is where it goes out sideways, dear. You talk other people's lives into shape and stay silent on your own.

You decided a while ago to stop explaining yourself to one particular person. You were right, and you have held to it.

Hold to it. The silence in your fourth is a different animal, and that one has to break.

HOUSE 4

home, and what you came from

Your choice has been guided to Judgment, a card of the old house calling you out



JUDGMENT

Three of them stand up out of coffins floating on grey water — a man on the left, a woman on the right, a child between them with its back turned. No one lifted those lids from outside. They came up of their own accord, arms wide, because something was sounded and they heard it.

The household you were made in is standing up in your life again. Not as memory, dear. As a matter someone raises with you in the open, expecting you to answer it out loud.

It comes all at once, and it does not come round a second time. That is why the child faces away — that part belongs to you, and no one else in the room saw it.

What this card hands you is the end of carrying it in private.

What it wants back is one plain telling: say the thing to one living person this month, undressed, no softening.

And who is it you have decided must never hear it?

romance, and what delights you

The cosmic forces have guided your selection to the Devil, a card of pleasure you help hold in place



THE DEVIL

Small horns have come up on both of them, and each has grown a tail — one ending in fire, one in grapes. Heat on the one, sweetness on the other. The arrangement made them over slowly, and it feeds them both.

Two figures, two collars, one ring. Two people are getting something real out of what you have now, which is why it sits so still.

So it is the arrival, not the renewal. In the room of what binds you a stone chariot is already driving forward, and it will not turn back to rekindle anything.

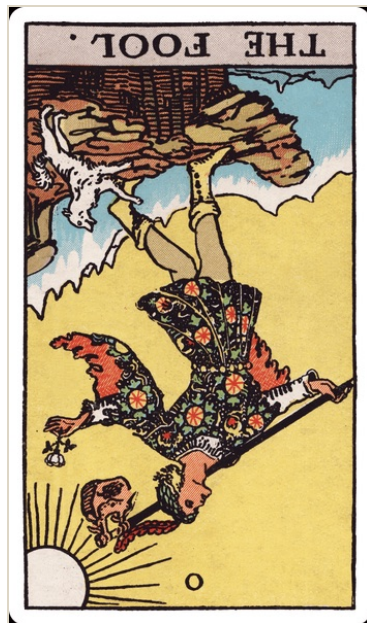
A twin flame, dear, and you know him already. The third week of next month. He is mid-errand, moving with purpose, not looking for you, and he stops.

I can date this room because an arrival is an event. The other eleven are weather.

He arrives on one day and is recognised on another. Do not brace for the second and miss the first.

work, health, the daily grind

Your choice fell on the Fool, a card of the beginning you declined



THE FOOL · REVERSED

The wallet swinging off the end of his wand has marks stitched into it, and not one of them adds up to a word. Embroidered, careful, and unreadable. Nothing on that bag records where he has been.

Your working week is stitched the same way. Effort goes in daily and leaves no entry behind it — no ledger, nothing you could hold up and say, this is what the year did.

Because the opening was real and you turned it down. You have called that prudence since, and the days have run identically ever since you called it that.

Strength came up reversed in your tenth. Your standing has not risen because the strength went inward — into holding the ordinary week steady rather than into anything new. That is

what tires you, dear. Not the work. The holding.

So write this week to whoever held that door and ask, plainly, whether it is still open.

who you are bound to

Your choice has fallen on the Chariot, a card of a bond still moving



THE CHARIOT

He is standing, not sitting — armour across his chest, in a chariot cut out of stone that nobody could turn by hand. Nothing about that vehicle was built to be reversed.

And there are no reins. The two sphinxes lie harnessed in front of him, one black, one white, and not one strap runs from his hands to either of them.

You have noticed this already. The tie you are in holds its shape and holds its speed, and you have not had a say in the heading for some time now — you thought it, and then told yourself you were being unfair.

The Devil sits in your fifth, and a thing that suits two people stays pointed exactly where it was pointed. That is why this will not turn back to be rekindled.

Left as it stands, dear, it takes you with it. The walled town gets smaller behind you, and you arrive somewhere you never chose.

Do not read that as a sentence passed on you. Read the eighth next, because the eighth is where the money comes from that turns it into a choice.

what is hidden, and what comes through others

The cosmos has turned your hand to the Empress



THE EMPRESS · REVERSED

Corn stands ripe in front of her and not one ear has been cut. It has been ready a long while. Whoever crosses that field first is who carries it off.

Your growing goes the same way. It gets taken at exactly the point it is worth taking, and the sceptre in her raised hand holds up a world that is not hers.

Now the second sum. The money in your second is paper — an office, a ledger, a figure reissued. This one is not. It comes through a person's hands: family money, a share being divided, released because somebody else decided it should be.

It moves your love life rather than your accounts because provision is what has kept you inside the arrangement in your fifth. Money you did not have to be given makes leaving a

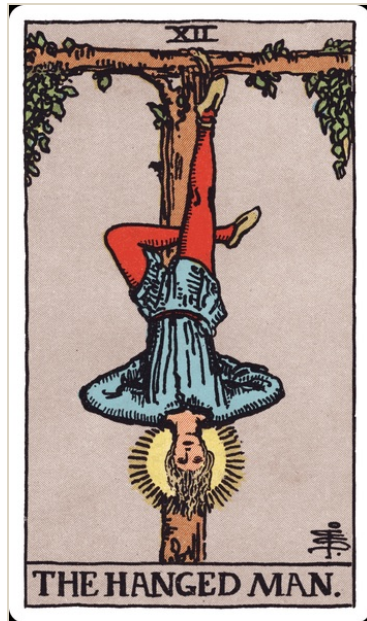
decision instead of a risk.

Read as a windfall and let it in among everyone's needs, dear, and it is absorbed without trace and the Devil keeps its collar on.

This room gives you the means, and takes back the first plain refusal you make this month.

what you believe

The celestial wisdom has guided your selection to the Hanged Man, a card of waiting she agreed to



THE HANGED MAN

The light around his head is a plain ring, no rays coming off it, and it hangs there while he does — as wide as his shoulders and no wider. Nothing above him is giving it to him. It is coming off the man himself, upside down and quiet.

You believe that going without now buys something later. You would not say that aloud in those words, and you would argue with anyone who said it back to you.

This card is not calling that belief a delusion, and it is not telling you the years were spent for nothing. It is telling you the arrangement is real — but it pays in sight, not in reward. What you have bought is knowing exactly how your life is shaped. Not a prize for endurance.

The wood he hangs from is alive, dear, and small green leaves are pushing out of it while he waits.

So that is what the waiting bought you. The tenth room is the bill for it.

your standing

Your choice has led you to Strength



STRENGTH · REVERSED

One grey hill stands a long way off behind her, and the ground between is empty — no road, no house, no other figure walking it. Nothing marks how far she has come. That is your standing: the distance is real and there is no record of it.

The holding is what has worn thin. Not the work, and not your temper.

Three places it shows. What gets said about you when you are not in the room. The job that lands on you because you will do it without being asked twice. And the moment someone else is thanked in front of you for a thing that was yours.

That third one is where it comes out badly now, dear — nothing for months, then all of it at once, and the wrong person catching it.

The flower chain round her waist runs on and loops the lion's neck. Same chain, both of them.

You already decided you would not go asking to be credited. Keep that.

your circle

Your selection has fallen to the High Priestess



THE HIGH PRIESTESS

Her robe goes down over the step and turns into water at the bottom edge, and there is no seam where cloth stops and pool begins. She is joined to what she is sitting above. You cannot get between them.

One woman in your circle is like that. She has gone quiet on you and there was no quarrel — she has simply stopped offering, and you have felt the change and put it down to yourself.

She has not cooled. She is holding something whole, dear, and half of it is still under her hand.

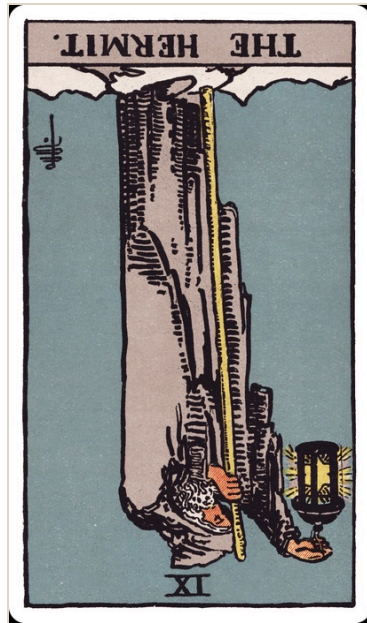
She will not bring it to you. That is not unkindness; it is her make, and she waits to be asked directly.

So ask her, this month, alone and in person — and what she tells you stops with you. That is the exchange. She gives you the full of it provided nothing you hear travels on.

Which of them has gone quiet without a reason you can name?

what is being kept from you

And your twelfth card is the Hermit, a quiet chosen once and never chosen again



THE HERMIT · REVERSED

The staff is gripped at its middle, well clear of the snow, taking no weight from the ground at all. He carries it. He does not lean on it, and he is not walking anywhere with it.

You made your own withdrawal deliberately and you were right to. What has not happened since is you putting the question to yourself a second time.

Here is the thing standing close and out of your sight. The one who breaks your ground is not somebody coming back from before — it is somebody already in your days who has begun leaving. Not shape. Begun, and far enough along that other people can see it. The bond in your seventh has no reins in it, stone-cut and moving. Nothing in that turns round to be asked.

Six points burn inside the glass, and the lamp shows one step of ground.

Ask him plainly this month, and take the first answer he gives.

—

Put the twelve together and they say one thing no card said on its own. You are being moved out of an arrangement, and you are being handed the money to go with.

The order is what matters. The leaving in your twelfth is already under way. The sum in your eighth follows it, through a person's hands. The arrival in your fifth comes last of the three.

The eighth is the condition of the other two. If that money comes late, the arrival becomes something you stand and watch instead of something you take, and the collar in your fifth stays buckled.

And the twelfth is not alone on the table. Judgment stood up in your fourth — a matter raised in the open, wanting one plain answer said out loud. The same demand made twice in one spread.

What changes for you is the order of knowing. You have been told things after they were decided elsewhere. Now you see them while they are still forming, and you get a hand in

them.

The first of it inside five to seven days: something on paper about money. A statement, a letter, an office reopening a figure you were told was closed.

I have dated one room only, dear, and it is your fifth, because an arrival is a single event and events can be timed. The other eleven I have not dated and will not. The two months are when the movement starts, not when all of it is finished — some rooms will have opened inside a fortnight, and the slow ones are slow because of the card standing in them.

This week, keep whatever comes on paper. And write the letter about that door.

And now the second part, dear — this one is yours to keep

When you have read your twelve properly — all of them, more than once — there is a second thing I want to give you, and it costs you nothing but a minute a night.

I said in my letter that the difference is not whether things happen to you. It is whether they happen to you from behind.

This is the practice that makes the difference. It is the only one I give away.

What it is

Twenty-eight nights. One line a night. That is the whole of it.

Each night before you sleep, you write down **one thing you noticed that day that was different from the day before.**

Not how you felt. Not what you hope. What you *noticed*. Something someone said that they don't usually say. A message that came at an odd hour. A silence where there is normally noise. The way a room went when you walked into it.

One line. Ordinary handwriting, ordinary paper, no ceremony. If nothing was different, write *nothing was different* — that is a real entry and you will want it later.

The reason is simple and it is not mystical, dear. Your twelfth house is holding something unsaid, and things like that are never invisible. They are only ever *unrecorded*. A woman notices eleven small wrong notes across a fortnight, forgets ten of them, and is genuinely astonished by the eleventh. She was told eleven times. She just had nowhere to put it.

The ledger is somewhere to put it.

The four turns

Nights 1 to 7 — the first turn. Just notice. Don't interpret, don't join anything up, and above all don't act on it. This week you are only training the eye. Write the line and close the book.

Your reading said the first sign shows itself inside five to seven days. It lands in this turn. You will not necessarily know it when it arrives — that is exactly why you are writing it down.

Nights 8 to 14 — the second turn. Same one line, and add a second only when you genuinely have one. By now you will start wanting to explain what you're writing. Resist it for

one more week. An explanation written the same night is almost always the explanation you already believed that morning.

Night 15 — the read-back. This is the night the practice pays. Do not write anything first. Sit down and read your fourteen lines in one sitting, in order, start to finish.

Something will come up off the page that was not visible on any single night. It always does. That is the whole reason for the fourteen — not one of those lines is worth much alone and together they are a pattern.

Then write your line for the fifteenth night, and write underneath it what you saw in the fourteen.

Nights 15 to 21 — the third turn. Now you know what you have been noticing, so notice *that*. Your attention has something to point at, and you will find you catch things on the day now instead of three days late.

Nights 22 to 28 — the fourth turn. Keep writing, and this week let yourself act on what you have found. Ask the question. Decline the thing. Say the sentence you have been keeping. You have three weeks of evidence behind you and you are no longer guessing.

On the twenty-eighth night, read the whole ledger through.

The two love weeks

In the weeks your reading named, pay particular attention to the people you come across.

Your fifth house has something already in motion toward you, and your reading has said in its own room whether it arrives as a stranger or as someone already in the frame. Either way it comes in small — which is precisely the kind of thing the eye skips and the ledger catches.

Someone you know may reappear in these weeks. Someone in the frame may step forward in it. Write it down on the night, in the ordinary way, even when it seems far too small to mean anything.

Especially then. The ones that matter almost always look too small on the night.

If nothing happens

Then you run the twenty-eight again.

I mean that plainly and not as a consolation. Some women's first cycle is all noise — four weeks of *nothing was different* — and their second cycle is the one that shows the shape. The practice is not a spell that either works or doesn't. It is an eye being trained, and eyes take a while.

The second twenty-eight is easier than the first, and it is the one where the read-back on the fifteenth night stops you cold.

And that is the gift

Keep the book. Not for me — I don't want to see it, and I'd rather you wrote freely than wrote something you'd be willing to show a reader.

Keep it because in eight weeks you are going to want to know whether you saw it coming.

You did. It will be on the page in your own handwriting, three weeks before it happened, in a line you thought was too small to matter.

That is what it is to stop finding out last.

These twelve were laid for you and for nobody else. The writing is assisted — I use a machine to help me put a reading into words. The draw is real and it is yours.

Evelyn